

A Mind Firmly Established in the Four Establishments of Mindfulness

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This was said by the Venerable Elder Sariputta in the sampasā-daniya sutta of the Dīgha Nikāya (DN 28):

So too, O Bhante, the drift of the dhamma is known by me. Whichever arahants, O Bhante, were rightly self-awakened Buddhas of the past, all those Auspicious Ones, having abandoned the five hindrances, mental defilements that are weakeners of wisdom, then with a mind well established in the four establishments of mindfulness, having enculturated the seven awakening factors, they rightly awakened to the supreme awakening.

—DN 28

This is in line with the explanation in the ānāpānasati sutta (MN 118), where the Buddha states that fulfilling the four establishments of mindfulness fulfills the seven awakening factors, and fulfilling the seven awakening factors fulfill noble knowledge and liberation (vijjavimuttiṃ).

Now how should this statement from the Elder Sariputta be understood?

1. How does a bodhisatta's mind, having been freed from the hindrances, become firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness?

2. How is a mind thus firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness enculturates the seven factors of awakening in such a way that they lead to supreme awakening?

To answer question one: “How does a bodhisatta’s mind having been freed from the hindrances, become firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness”, it is important to understand what a bodhisatta is. *Bodhi* means awakened and *satta* means a being. So a *bodhisatta* is an *awakened being*. An ariya, not a puthujjana. A “puthujjana bodhisatta” is simply a contradiction in terms. Given that bodhisattas acknowledge their bodhisattahood once they arise in the Tusita heaven, clearly comprehending that their next human birth will be their last birth, a bodhisatta most likely enters the Tusita heaven either as a one-seed-attainer sotapanna (a stream enterer who only returns to the human world once, see saupādisesa sutta, AN 9.12) or a sakadagami (a once-returner). In the tissa sutta (AN 7.56), the Buddha leaves open the possibility of one who becomes an ariya by going beyond the attainment of the domain of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and discovering the signless samādhi outside of a Buddha’s teaching, but becoming a bodhisatta through such a discovery must be extremely rare compared to those who become bodhisattas through the teaching of other Buddhas. Afterall, a sotapanna is defined as one who is “no longer subject to the lower destinations, on a fixed course, destined for **supreme awakening** (avinipātadhammo, niyato, *sambhodi* parāyaṇo); and a bodhisatta is defined as one who is just an awakened being, not yet fully awakened to **supreme awakening** (*sambodhā* anabhisambuddhassa bodhisattasseva). And so it was with our Bodhisatta Gotama who lived the life of purity under the arahant, the rightly self-awakened Buddha Kassapa (see ghaṭikāra sutta MN 81) prior to arising in the Tusita heaven. Even as a householder, the Bodhisatta acknowledged being an ariya when he said in the sukhumāla sutta, AN 3.36):

I was delicate, O bhikkhus, supremely delicate, excessively delicate. Indeed at my father’s residence, these lotus ponds were built purposely for me. In one entirely white lotuses were planted, in one red lotuses, in one blue lotuses. I, O bhikkhus, did not wear sandalwood that were not from Kasi. My turban, O bhikkhus, were from Kasi, my jackets were from Kasi, my inner robes were from Kasi, my outer robes were from Kasi. A white parasol, O bhikkhus, was

held over me day and night [with the thought]: Let neither cold, nor heat, nor grass, nor dust, nor dew touch him.

Of me being endowed with such great fortune, O bhikkhus, with such delicacy, it occurred to me: “For the Dhamma-deaf puthujjana, himself being liable to old age, not exempt, having seen others who are old, becomes troubled, humiliated, disgusted, having overlooked his own [liability]. But if I, being liable to old age, not exempt, having seen others who are old, were to become troubled, humiliated, disgusted, that would not be proper for me.” Of me, O bhikkhus, reflecting thus, I abandoned all the youth’s intoxication with youth.

–AN 3.36

And in the bhayabherava sutta (MN 4), the Buddha acknowledges being an ariya as follows:

It occurred to me thus, O Brahmin: Whatever samanas or brahmanas with perplexity and doubt make use of dwelling places in remote forest thickets, then indeed with perplexity and doubt as cause, those venerable samanas and brahmanas invoke unskillful fear and dread. But I am not one who makes use of dwelling places in remote forest thickets with perplexity or doubt. I have crossed over doubt. I am indeed a certain one among those ariyas gone beyond doubt who make use of dwelling places in remote forest thickets. Seeing this crossing over doubt within myself, O Brahmin, I dwelt even more unafraid in the forest.

–MN 4

We also get a glimpse of the Bodhisatta Gotama’s progress towards full awakening as an ariya in the kālī sutta (AN 10.26):

Some samanas and brahmanas, O sister, actualized the earth kasina as the highest goal. The Auspicious One understood with supreme knowledge, the extent to which that earth kasina is supreme. Having understood that with supreme knowledge, the Auspicious one saw the beginning, saw the danger, saw the escape, saw the knowledge and

vision of the path and the non-path. [With] his vision of the beginning as cause, vision of danger as cause, vision of escape as cause, knowledge and vision of the path and the non-path as cause, he has known the attainment of the goal, the peace of the heart.

–AN 10.26

Because as an ariya, the Bodhisatta Gotama possessed the knowledge and vision of the path and the non-path, he knew that even attainments of the domain of nothingness and the domain of neither-perception-nor-non-perception which surpass the kasina attainments, were also not the supreme goal as taught by his former teachers Ālāra Kālāma and Udāka Rāmaputta, and therefore was able to surmount these attainments and awaken to the supreme awakening.

Now the knowledge of the overcoming of doubt is the hallmark of an ariya who is at least a stream enterer (sotapanna). Along with this knowledge, the knowledge and vision of the path and the non-path becomes the starting point (ādim) of purification towards supreme awakening. As the Buddha explains in the kosambiya sutta (MN 48), the five hindrances do not obsess the mind of an ariya in such a way that he will not know and see things as they have come to be. His mind is well inclined for the truths, for awakening. This is a knowledge attained by him that is noble, supramundane, not in common with puthujjanas.

With the five hindrances not obsessing the mind, the ariya then abides in the body seeing in accordance with the arising and vanishing nature of things as they have come to be for abandoning the hindrances and giving rise to the seven awakening factors. This is an ariyan abiding not accessible to puthujjanas as explained in the samudayadhamma sutta (SN 22.126) as follows:

Then a certain bhikkhu visited with the Auspicious One. Upon arrival, he bowed down to the Auspicious One and sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One: “Ignorance, ignorance” O Bhante, it is said. What, O Bhante, is ignorance? To what extent is one entrenched in ignorance?

“Here O Bhikkhu, the Dhamma-deaf puthujjana does not wisely understand as it has come to be “form is of a nature

to arise as form is of a nature to arise.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “form is of a nature to vanish as form is of a nature to vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise and vanish as form is of a nature to arise and vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be feeling..., perception..., sankharas..., “consciousness is of a nature to arise as consciousness is of a nature to arise.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to vanish as consciousness is of a nature to vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish as consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish.” This, O Bhikkhu, is called ignorance. It is to this extent that one is entrenched in ignorance.”

When thus was said, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One. “noble knowledge, noble knowledge,” O Bhante, it is said. What, O Bhante, is noble knowledge? To what extent is one well settled in noble knowledge?

“Here O Bhikkhu, the Dhamma-hearer, the noble disciple, wisely understands as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise as form is of a nature to arise.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “form is of a nature to vanish as form is of a nature to vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise and vanish as form is of a nature to arise and vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be feeling..., perception..., sankharas..., “consciousness is of a nature to arise as consciousness is of a nature to arise.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to vanish as consciousness is of a nature to vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish as consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish.” This, O Bhikkhu, is called noble knowledge. It is to this extent that one is well settled in noble knowledge.”
–SN 22.126

And in the vibhanga sutta (SN 47.40), the satipatthana is explained as a path to be enculturated by ariyas as follows:

And what, O bhikkhus, is the enculturation of the establishment of mindfulness? Here, O bhikkhus, having put away worldly covetousness and longing, a bhikkhu abides in the body perceiving in accordance with its nature to arise as an ardent, contemplative and mindful one. Having put away worldly covetousness and longing, he abides in the body perceiving in accordance with its nature to vanish as an ardent, contemplative and mindful one. Having put away worldly covetousness and longing, he abides in the body perceiving in accordance with its nature to arise and vanish as an ardent, contemplative and mindful one.
–SN 47.40

As the ariya abides thus ardent, contemplative and mindful in the body perceiving in accordance with the body, the five hindrances become entirely abandoned, the perception of light (*ālokasañña*) becomes well grasped, and the penetrative vision (*vipassana*) becomes apparent, revealing the transparency of all *sankharas* and their nature to arise and to vanish all the more. In the *padhāniyaṅga* sutta, the Buddha calls this vision “the wisdom that sees arising and vanishing, which is of the noble, penetrative type that leads to the thorough extinction of suffering.” The possession of this penetrative vision is one of the five endowments he requires in a disciple for a successful training in the noble ones discipline. This penetrative vision culminates in knowledge and vision, also called the vision of the Dhamma or the Dhamma Cakkhu, where the eye ceases and perception of forms fade away. The Buddha gives a nice simile for this knowledge and vision attainment in the *samāññaphala* sutta (DN 2) as follows:

Suppose, O Great King, that there were a beautiful beryl gem, flawless, with eight facets, of excellent workmanship, finely crafted, transparent, bright, placid, perfect in every way, strung therein with either a blue or yellow or red or white or brown thread. Of them a man with good eyes having held it in his hands would review thus: “This beautiful beryl gem, flawless, with eight facets, of excellent workmanship, finely crafted, transparent, bright, placid, perfect in every way, is strung therein with either a blue or yellow or red or white or brown thread.”

So too, O Great King, with a mind thus purified, cleansed, unblemished, devoid of defilements, malleable, workable,

steady, and attained to imperturbability, a bhikkhu inclines and directs it to knowledge and vision. He wisely understands thus: “This body of mine composed of form made of the four great elements, originating from father and mother, an accumulation of rice and porridge, is impermanent, subject to rubbing, pressing, breaking up, falling apart, and yet this consciousness of mine is dependent on it here, bound up with it here.”

–MN 2

The joy (pamojja) that arises from the abandoning of the hindrances give rise to happiness (pītisambojjhaṅga). For one who is happy in mind, the body becomes tranquil (passaddhisambojjhaṅga). One whose body is tranquil feels pleasure. The mind of one who feels pleasure gains samādhi (samādhisambojjhaṅga). This non-sensual pleasure engulfs the entire body, from the top of the skull to the soles of the feet, leading to unwavering mindfulness of the body (satisambojjhaṅga). At this point, the mind is said to be firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness, clearly seeing the nature of the body to vanish, along with any forms cognizable by the eye. This is also said to be an abiding with samatha and vipassana yoked evenly together in the mahāsaḷāyatanika sutta, (MN 149).

Now the four establishments of mindfulness are said to be the samādhi nimittā of the sammāsamādhi noble eight-fold path factor in the cūḷavedalla sutta (MN 44):

Friend Visakha, the unique peak of mind is samādhi. The four establishments of mindfulness are the signs of samādhi. The four right strivings are the requisites of samādhi. The pursuit, enculturation, and making-abundant of these same dhammas is the enculturation of samādhi therein.”

–MN 44

In the piṇḍoliya sutta (SN 22.80) and the samaṇamaṇḍikā sutta (MN 78), the mind in jhāna is said to be a mind firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness as follows:

“There are, O bhikkhus, these three kinds of unwholesome thoughts— sensual thoughts, thoughts of ill will, thoughts

of harming. And where, O bhikkhus, do these three unwholesome thoughts cease without remainder? For one who dwells with a mind firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness, or for one who develops the signless samādhī. This is reason enough, O bhikkhus, to develop the signless samādhī.

–SN 22.80

And the samaṇamañḍikā sutta (MN 78), further explains:

But what, O Carpenter, are unwholesome intentions? They are the intention of sensual desire, the intention of ill will, and the intention of cruelty. These, O Carpenter, are called unwholesome intentions.

But these unwholesome intentions, O Carpenter, what do they originate from? Their origin is stated: they should be said to originate from perception.

What perception? For perceptions are many, varied, and of different aspects, There is perception of sensual desire, perception of ill will, and perception of cruelty. Unwholesome intentions originate from this.

But where, O Carpenter, do these unwholesome intentions cease without remainder? Their cessation is stated: Here, quite secluded from sense-desires, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion, with thinking and with pondering, the first jhāna. It is here that unwholesome intentions cease without remainder.

–MN 78

From these suttas, we see that a mind in jhāna is said to be a mind firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness. The jhāna similes in the suttas make it very clear why a mind that dwells in the jhānas is a mind firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness (see kāyagatāsati sutta, MN 119).

With regard to mindfulness of the body (kāyānupassanā), the ariya attains unwavering mindfulness of the body while in the first jhāna, although that mindfulness is not yet purified due to the presence of

happiness in the mind along with thinking and pondering, as well as bodily pleasure. The first jhāna simile of the body being saturated by pleasure with happiness like a bath powder saturated with moisture but not dripping, makes the unwavering mindfulness of the body while in the first jhāna abundantly clear as follows:

Furthermore, O bhikkhus, quite secluded from sense-desires, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion, with thinking and with pondering, the first jhāna. He drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion.

Just as, O bhikkhus, an expert bath attendant or bath attendant's apprentice, having splashed and sprinkled bath-soap powder with water, would mix it. His ball of soap would be permeated with moisture, saturated with moisture, drenched with moisture inside and out but without dripping.

So too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion. Of him dwelling thus vigilant, ardent and resolute, his memories and intentions connected with the home life gets abandoned. With their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samādhi. Thus too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu develops mindfulness of the body.

—MN 119

In the second jhāna, the mind is quietened by the absence of thinking and pondering (ariyan silence) and the unwavering mindfulness of the body becomes more purified, but still not fully purified due to the presence of happiness and bodily pleasure. The second jhāna simile of the body being permeated with pleasure with happiness like a welling spring in a lake saturating the entire lake with cool water, makes the unwavering mindfulness of the body while in the second jhāna abundantly clear as follows:

Furthermore, O bhikkhus, from the subsiding of thinking and pondering, with the internal tranquilization and unification of mind, without thinking and pondering, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the pleasure with happiness born of samādhi, the second jhāna. He drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with the pleasure with happiness born of samādhi. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the pleasure with happiness born of samādhi.

Suppose, O bhikkhus, there were a deep lake with water springing up. Of that there would neither be inflow of water from the eastern direction, nor inflow of water from the northern direction, nor inflow of water from the western direction, nor inflow of water from the southern direction, and the rain deva would not supply proper rain-shower from time to time. Then a cool stream of water having welled up from just that lake, would drench, soak, completely fill and saturate just that lake with cool water, there would not be any part of the entire lake not permeated with cool water.

So too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with the pleasure with happiness born of samādhi. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the pleasure with happiness born of samādhi. Of him dwelling thus vigilant, ardent and resolute, his memories and intentions connected with the home life gets abandoned. With their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samādhi. Thus too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu develops mindfulness of the body.

In the third jhāna, unwavering mindfulness of the body is still there but the mind has withdrawn from the happiness and dwells equanimous to the bodily pleasure. The Buddha describe this as abiding mindful and contemplative (*sati sampajāna*), and the ariyas praise one who abides in such a way thus: “The mindful one is he who dwells in pleasure with equanimity.” But utter purity of mindfulness is still lacking due to the presence of the bodily pleasure. The third jhāna simile of the body being permeated with the pleasure without happiness like a lotus flower submerged in water being permeated by the coolness of that water makes the unwavering mindfulness of

the body while in the third jhāna abundantly clear as follows:

Furthermore, O bhikkhus, with the fading away of happiness, a bhikkhu dwelling mindful and ” ”contemplative, looks on with equanimity as he experiences pleasure in the body, ” ”of which the Noble Ones say: “The mindful one is he who dwells in pleasure with equanimity.” He enters upon and abides in the third jhana. He drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with the pleasure without happiness. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the pleasure without happiness.

Suppose, O bhikkhus, there were a blue lotus pond, a red lotus pond, or a white lotus pond. Some blue lotus or red lotus or white lotus born in the water, grown up in the water, not risen out of the water, immersed and nourished inside. The cool water would drench, soak, completely fill and saturate it from the very roots to the very top so that there would not be any part of the entire blue lotus or red lotus or white lotus not permeated with the coolness of the water.

So too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu drenches, soaks, completely fills and saturates this very body with the pleasure without happiness. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the pleasure without happiness. Of him dwelling thus vigilant, ardent and resolute, his memories and intentions connected with the home life gets abandoned. With their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samādhi. Thus too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu develops mindfulness of the body.

It is only in the fourth jhāna where the mind and the body have become unified in equanimity and ideations about the mental tranquility ceases (passaddhattā cetaso anābhogo) that unwavering mindfulness of the body and equanimity is said to have reached its utter purity. The fourth jhāna simile of a person completely covered by a white cloth from head to feet makes the unwavering mindfulness of the body while in the fourth jhāna abundantly clear as follows:

Furthermore, O bhikkhus, from the abandoning of [physical] pleasure and pain, from the extinction of former mental pleasure and mental pain, a bhikkhu enters upon and abides in the utter purity of mindfulness and equanimity without pain, without pleasure, the fourth jhana. He sits having completely filled this very body with a purity and brightness of mind. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with purity and brightness of mind.

Just as, O bhikkhus, a man would sit having covered himself with a white cloth up to the head, so that there would be no part of his entire body not covered with white cloth.

So too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu sits having completely filled this very body with the purity and brightness of mind. There is not any part of his entire body not permeated with the purity and brightness of mind. Of him dwelling thus vigilant, ardent and resolute, his memories and intentions connected with the home life gets abandoned. With their abandoning he steadies his mind internally, quietens it, unifies it and stills it in samādhi. Thus too, O bhikkhus, a bhikkhu develops mindfulness of the body.

With regard to mindfulness of feelings (vedanānupassanā), the ariya knows that with a mind thus firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness, the pleasant or equanimous feelings that are being experienced are not sensual (nirāmisa).

With regard to mindfulness of mental states (cittānupassanā), the ariya knows that a mind thus firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness is a state of mind without lust (vītarāgaṃ), without hate (vītadosaṃ), without delusion (vītamohaṃ), not contracted (not sankhittaṃ), not distracted (not vikkhittaṃ), not exulted (amahaggaṃ), surpassable (sauttaraṃ, higher jhānas or formless āyatanas surpass it), in samādhi (samāhitaṃ), unliberated if the ariya is not yet an arahant (avimuttaṃ).

With regard to mindfulness of dhammas (dhammānupassanā), the ariya knows by supreme knowledge (abhiññā) how the abandoned five hindrances do not arise in the future; he knows by supreme knowledge the five appropriable khandhas, their arising and their vanishing; he knows by supreme knowledge how the non-arisen fetters do not arise in the future with respect to the six internal and

external āyatanas; he knows by supreme knowledge how the arisen awakening factors go to full maturation by inculturation; and he knows by supreme knowledge the four noble truths.

Now to answer question two: How does a mind thus firmly established in the four establishments of mindfulness enculturate the seven awakening factors in such a way that they lead to supreme awakening, it is important to know that the seven awakening factors are also a path to be treaded by ariyas, outside the plane of a puthujjana, as made clear in the udayi sutta (SN 46.30):

Indeed I, O Bhante, gone to an empty hut, setting in motion the restoration and inversion in these five appropriable khandhas, understood with supreme knowledge as it has come to be: “This is suffering;” understood with supreme knowledge as it has come to be: “This is the origination of suffering;” understood with supreme knowledge as it has come to be: “This is the cessation of suffering;” understood with supreme knowledge as it has come to be: “This is the path leading to the cessation of suffering.”

The breakthrough to the Dhamma has been made by me, O Bhante, and the path has been obtained by me which when encultured and made abundant by me dwelling in the appropriate way, will lead [me] onwards to the state of being thus, as I will understand: “Destroyed is birth, lived is the life of purity, done is what had to be done, there is nothing else for thusness.” The awakening factor of mindfulness, O Bhante, has been obtained by me..., the awakening factor of investigation of dhammas, O Bhante, has been obtained by me..., the awakening factor of energy, O Bhante, has been obtained by me..., the awakening factor of happiness, O Bhante, has been obtained by me..., the awakening factor of tranquility, O Bhante, has been obtained by me..., the awakening factor of samādhī, O Bhante, has been obtained by me..., the awakening factor of equanimity, O Bhante, has been obtained by me which when encultured and made abundant by me dwelling in the appropriate way, will lead [me] onwards to the state of being thus, as I will understand: “Destroyed is birth, lived is the life of purity, done is what had to be done, there is nothing else for thusness.”

–SN 46.30

With a mind thus firmly established in the four satipatthanas, the five hindrances are completely abandoned and the arisen seven awakening factors are then used as the energy lever to maintain this samatha and vipassana yoked together until it culminates in the vision of the Dhamma as explained in the aggi sutta (SN 46.53). The ariya directs the mind to the investigation of dhammas awakening factor, the energy awakening factor and the happiness awakening factor as needed if the mind needs more arousal, or else he directs the mind to the tranquility awakening factor and the samadhi awakening factor if the mind needs further calming; or else he looks on with equanimity at the mind thus attained to samadhi as he directs the mind to the equanimity awakening factor (upekkhāsambojjhaṅga). The mindfulness awakening factor is present in all these cases.

In the taṇhakkhaya sutta (SN 46.26) the Buddha explains how the seven awakening factors are enculturated so as to lead to the extinction of suffering as follows:

“Here, O Udayi, a bhikkhu enculturates the mindfulness awakening factor in dependence on seclusion, in dependence on fading away, in dependence on cessation, maturing in relinquishment, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, free from affliction. For him enculturating the mindfulness awakening factor in dependence on seclusion, in dependence on fading away, in dependence on cessation, maturing in relinquishment, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, free from affliction, there is the abandoning of thirsting. With the abandoning of thirsting, there is the abandoning of kamma. With the abandoning of kamma, there is the abandoning of suffering. Thus, O Udayi, from the extinction of thirsting comes the extinction of kamma. From the extinction of kamma comes the extinction of suffering.”

–SN 46.26

In the samādhi sutta (AN 5.27), the Buddha instructs his ariya disciples to enculturate this vision of the dhamma samadhi, which he explains as “the samadhi that is immeasurable”. This ariyan samādhi is the ariya’s knowledge and vision as described above. One of the

knowledges that the ariya reviews when in such an attainment is described as follows:

The knowledge arises that is personally yours: “This samādhi is peaceful and excellent, gained by full tranquilization, and attained to unification. It is not arrived at and held in check by keeping it in place with force.”

–AN 5.27

In the ānanda sutta (AN 9.37), the Buddha declares that abiding in this ariya immeasurable samādhi has final knowledge (aññā) as its fruit.

Sister, the samadhi that does not lean forward and does not bend back, and that is not arrived at and held in check by keeping it in place with force. By being liberated, it is steady; by being steady, it is content; by being content, one is not agitated. The Auspicious One said that this samadhi has final knowledge as its fruit.

–AN 9.37

This ariya samādhi is also known as viññāṇanirodha or viññāṇaṃ anidassanaṃ anantaṃ sabbato pabhaṃ in kevaddha sutta (DN 11) and ānantariko cetosamādhi in the dasuttara sutta (DN 34) or ratana sutta (Snp 2.1).

Now the four jhanas, the domain of infinite space, the domain of infinite consciousness, the domain of nothingness, as well as other samadhi attainments such as the four brahmaviharas that act as a gateway for touching cessation, are said to be unique peak of perception attainments (saññagga) in the potthapada sutta (DN 9). As the ariya’s vipassana culminates in the vision of the Dhamma with a mind well established in the four establishments of mindfulness, he then compares the peace of nibbana being experienced with the cessation of the eye, with the pleasure or equanimity of the body and mind in jhana. Now the experiencing of the peace of nibbana is described in the āpaṇa sutta (SN 48.50) as follows:

santametam padaṃ, paṇītametaṃ padaṃ, yadidaṃ sab-
basāṅkhārasamatho sabbūpadhipaṭṭinissaggo taṇhakkhaya

virāgo nirodho nibbānaṃ

“This is the peaceful path, this is the most excellent path, that is, the stilling of all sankharas, the relinquishing of all ownership, the extinction of thirsting, fading away, cessation, nibbana.”

–SN 48.50

Upon such comparison, it becomes quite obvious that the peace of nibbana the ariya is experiencing with the cessation of the eye is far more peaceful than the pleasure or equanimity of the jhana that he is experiencing with the body and mind, and so he acknowledges this fact as in the jhāna sutta (AN 9.36):

He sees whatever dhammas there pertaining to form, feeling, perception, sankharas, and consciousness as impermanent, suffering, a disease, a tumor, a dart, a calamity, an affliction, alien, disintegrating, empty, non-self. He withdraws the mind from those dhammas. Having withdrawn the mind from those dhammas, he directs the mind to the deathless element thus: “This is peaceful, this is the most excellent, that is, the stilling of all sankharas, the relinquishing of all ownership, the extinction of thirsting, fading away, cessation, nibbana.” If he is steady therein, he attains the extinction of the asavas. If he does not attain the extinction of the asavas because of that lust for the Dhamma, that delight in the Dhamma, then with the extinction of the five lower fetters he comes to arise spontaneously [in the pure abodes] as one who attains nibbana there, not subject to return from that world.

–AN 9.36

When the ariya turns his mind away from all sankharas and directs it to the deathless element thus, the entire body and mind join in the experience of cessation, not only the eye. If he can remain steady in it, he emerges as an arahant with all asavas destroyed. If he attains arahantship without the help of an existing Buddha’s teaching and establishes an order of the four assemblies of bhikkhus, bhikkhunis, male lay disciples and female lay disciples, then he is a samma sambuddha. If he attains arahantship without the help of an

existing Buddha's teaching but does not establish an order of the four assemblies, then he is a *paccekkha buddha*.

This is how all Auspicious Ones of the past, having abandoned the five hindrances, mental defilements that are weakeners of wisdom, and with a mind well established in the four establishments of mindfulness, enculturated the seven awakening factors and rightly awakened to the supreme awakening.

The Buddha succinctly summarizes this in his answer to the questions of Udaya in the *parāyana* of the *sutta nipāta* (Snp 5.14) as follows:

jhāyiṃ virajamāsinam (iccā yasmā udayo)
katakiccaṃ anāsavam;
pāraguṃ sabbadhammānaṃ,
atthi pañehana āgamaṃ;
aññā vimokkhaṃ pabrūhi,
avijjāya pabhedanaṃ.

pahānaṃ kāmacchandanaṃ (udayāti bhagavā)
domanassānaṃ cubhayaṃ,
thinassa ca panudanaṃ;
kukkuccānaṃ nivāraṇaṃ.

upekhā sati saṃsuddhaṃ,
dhammatakkapurejayaṃ;
aññā vimokkhaṃ pabrūmi,
avijjāya pabhedanaṃ.

To the meditator seated untainted,
who has done the to-be-done, asava-free;
the one who has gone beyond all dhammas,
there is a question I have come with;
speak of the liberation by final knowledge,
the breaking up of ignorance.

The abandoning of both,
lustful desire and mental pain;
the dispelling of the hindrances,
of sluggishness and doubt.

With equanimity and mindfulness well purified,
with a [mind] bent on the Dhamma swiftly in
front;
is the liberation by final knowledge, I speak of,
the breaking up of ignorance.
–Snp 5.14

The first verse of the Buddha's response to the venerable Udaya's question refers to the abandoning of the hindrances, mental defilements that are weakeners of wisdom. The well purified equanimity and mindfulness is a mind well established in the four establishments of mindfulness in the fourth jhana. A mind bent on the dhamma swiftly in front (*dhammatakka purejavam*), is nothing other than the mind well bent on the deathless element leading the way, with the vision of the dhamma as its perception. This immeasurable abiding has final knowledge (*añña*) as its fruits, as quoted above from the *ānanda sutta* (AN 9.37), the breaking up of ignorance.

This path treaded by all the Auspicious Ones of the past is the path of purification. It is just the same path that all those who have made the breakthrough to the four noble truths and crossed over doubt tread. Without making the breakthrough to the four noble truths, such purification that leads to the attainment of arahantship, and consequently attainment of buddhahood, is simply not possible, as made clear in the *āmagandha sutta* (Snp 2.2):

Neither by no fish and meat, nor by fasting,
neither by nakedness, nor by shaven-head;
neither by matted locks, nor being caked in mud,
neither by rough antelope hide, nor by devotion to fire
worship;
or even those in the world, who mortify themselves in
many ways for the immortal,
neither by incantation and fire oblations, nor devotion to
sacrifices and seasonal ascetic practices,
can purify mortals, who have not crossed over doubt.
–Snp 2.2